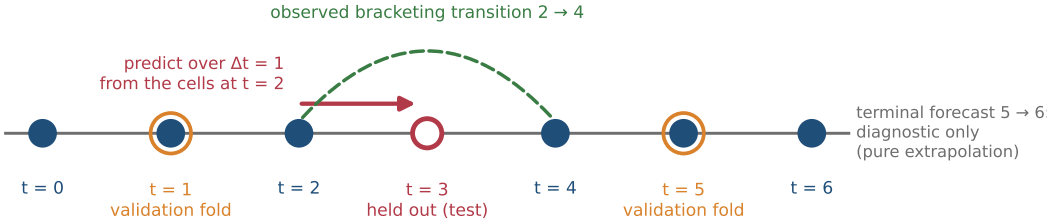
Evaluation protocol: leave-one-inner-time-point-out interpolation with nested selection



Controls fitted on the same observed cells, scored in the same standardised gene space:

- persistence
- mean interpolation
- McCann / OT interpolant
- linear map, same horizon
- MLP map, same horizon
- velocity replay
- flow model, shuffled time labels

Metrics: energy distance (U-statistic, primary), unbiased MMD, assignment W_2, error of means, per-gene W_1;
permutation null (50 splits); five seeds; paired 95% t-intervals.
Selection: mean validation energy distance over the two validation folds (t = 1 and t = 5), two search seeds;
the test point is never touched. Verdict: below every control, paired CI95 < 0 vs the best control, better than shuffled time.